sometimes even greater than those of India.[74] Nehru asserted in parliament that China's failures were not as evident because of fear, censorship, and the lack of openness. This, he felt, only made it more likely that "the lid" would come off and "terrible criticism" would emerge later.[75]

Nehru and other officials tried to keep track of the steps China was taking, both to see how India compared and to see if Delhi could adapt some of its policies.[76] At a planning commission meeting, he admitted that industrially China had moved past India.[77] He was impressed by its reported progress and by how the Chinese leadership was "letting all flowers blossom" (wrongly interpreted at the time as an opening up) and weeding out corruption.[78] But he noted that Beijing could do things by decree in a way that Delhi could not because of India's democratic nature.[79]

Nonetheless, according to Nehru, democracy made India's seemingly slower progress more sustainable than that of China. Delhi was tackling a different, more complex task: trying to achieve a "peaceful socioeconomic revolution" after having established a democracy. Overall, development might take longer, but he publicly asserted that democracy was "the sounder way of doing things."[80]

It seemed so when reports of Chinese economic difficulties started emerging in late summer 1957. Nehru exchanged information on these problems with foreign officials, including the American ambassador.[81] The Indian ambassador in China also reported signs of discontent.[82] Nehru highlighted for Indian chief ministers Mao's backsliding from promises of openness, which suggested a return to "the old rigidity."[83] He would eventually also question Chinese production statistics, since they seemed "almost sensational."[84]

Ultimately, however, Nehru knew that his government had to deliver. India was at a critical development stage, with limited time to strengthen itself. Like many US policymakers, he believed India could not slow down because, in Asia, "one has to make good quickly, otherwise one is swallowed up by other forces."[85] Development was crucial for the nation-building project, the sustainability of democracy, the expansion of the defense industrial base, and domestic political purposes. Moreover, globally "we can be only as powerful as we are domestically strong."[86]

Thus Nehru rejected calls in India that his government significantly "tone down" the second five-year plan despite the heavy lift it required, and